



A PLANNER'S GUIDE TO PRODUCTION BUDGETS

The Levers of Labor

What actually drives the biggest line on your production budget, and the one lever you control.

WRITTEN FOR

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Labor is almost always the biggest line item on your production budget. And unlike gear, it doesn't discount. Rates are rates.

But *not discountable* isn't the same as *not manageable*. The labor number on your proposal isn't a fixed cost of doing business. It's the output of a handful of decisions, most of them made before anyone sends you a price. Once you can see those decisions, you can have a real conversation about them instead of asking for a percentage off and getting nowhere.

Here's how that number actually gets built.

WHERE IT BEGINS

It starts with your quality target

Before anyone counts technicians, somebody has to answer a question only you can answer: **how many mistakes, miscues, and delays are acceptable?**

There's a spectrum, and both ends are achievable. Technical disaster is cheap. Perfection is extremely expensive: redundant technicians running redundant systems, testing and retesting everything, rehearsing until nothing can surprise them.

Almost nobody wants either end. In practice, my clients target excellent execution. The show moves like clockwork, the room never sees the seams, and the handful of things that go sideways get solved before anyone notices.

That's the target. Everything that follows is about hitting it without overpaying for it.

Running parallel to that quality spectrum is a cost spectrum, and it's driven by four levers your production company pulls in response to the target you set, plus a fifth lever that belongs to you.

LEVER ONE

Quality of labor

This one is mostly about geography.

Every production company hires local crew. Hands for load-in and strike, and local technicians as camera operators, breakout floaters, and utility positions to round out the show crew. That's standard practice everywhere, and it's a good thing. It's cheaper than flying everyone in, and local crews know the building.

What varies is the depth of the pool.

In a smaller market, the labor pool is thinner and generally less experienced. You may get excellent people. You may get people whose résumé is more optimistic than their reps. Top-tier markets like Las Vegas and Orlando have deep benches of highly skilled, experienced technicians who work big rooms every week.

But here's the part that surprises planners: those top-tier markets are also where all the work is. When the city is full, competition for the best techs is fierce, and the good ones are booked. A strong market is not automatically a cheap or easy one. It's a market where the difference between the best crew and the available crew is widest.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Ask about the market before you assume the crew plan is padded.

LEVER TWO

Project scope

Scope means two things, size and complexity, and they are not equally expensive.

Size is mostly duplication. More attendees means more components: more speakers, more screens, more breakouts. But each additional screen is usually projecting the same image the last one is. It costs money in gear, and it costs some money in labor, but it doesn't demand much *additional skill*.

Complexity is where the money is. Multiple video sources cutting live. Playback tightly synced to a presenter. A show that changes between rehearsal and doors. Presenters walking on with content nobody has seen yet. Complexity requires highly skilled engineers even when the audience is 100 people.

A 2,000-person general session with a lectern, two screens, and a deck is a simpler labor problem than a 150-person executive meeting with live switching, a q-and-a that has to be captured, and a CEO who rewrites his slides at 11pm.

And the more skilled the technician, the more expensive that technician is.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

If your show got more complex, expect the labor line to move even if the headcount didn't.

LEVER THREE

Local vs. travel (known vs. unknown)

The next two levers are your production company's *reaction* to the first two. Having read the market and the scope, they have to decide who they bring and who they hire.

This is really a question of known versus unknown.

Do I fly in the audio engineer I've worked with for seven years, who has never missed a cue and who I don't have to watch? Or do I hire a local A1, because this show is a lectern mic and three wireless and there's very little to get wrong?

That choice has a price, and it's worth seeing it laid out. A rough shape of what it costs to travel one technician to a three-day show:

COST TO TRAVEL ONE TECHNICIAN · THREE-DAY SHOW	
Round-trip air	\$600
Hotel, 5 nights	\$1,250
Per diem, 5 days	\$375
Travel days (2)	\$1,200
Ground, bags, parking	\$150
Premium over hiring local	≈ \$3,500

Illustrative. Your actual numbers will swing with the market, the season, and how far out you booked.

Roughly \$3,500 to remove a specific risk in a specific position, versus \$0 to accept it.

That's the judgment call your production company makes for every single crew member, and across a full crew it can move your labor budget by five figures.

The pattern most good companies follow: **key positions travel, everything else goes local**. The people who carry the show are the ones whose mistakes the room actually sees: the technical lead or producer, the audio engineer, the screens/video director, and the lighting designer on a heavily lit show. Camera operators, breakout techs, spot ops, and stagehands are far more safely hired in market.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

When you see travel costs on a proposal, the question isn't "why are we flying people in?" It's "which risk does each of these people remove, and is it worth the premium on *this* show?"

LEVER FOUR

Quantity of labor

Once you know the market, the scope, and the travel crew, the last question is the simplest to state and the easiest to get wrong: **how many people?**

This is the single biggest dollar driver on the labor line, because crew size multiplies against everything else: days, hours, and rates.

A few things that quietly inflate it:

- **Set and strike are separate from show days.** A crew that runs a two-day meeting might be onsite for five.
- **Overtime.** Most crews work a ten-hour day. Past that, hours bill at a premium, and a missed meal break can add penalties on top. A schedule that routinely runs eleven hours doesn't cost ten percent more than a ten-hour schedule. It costs considerably more.
- **The building.** Union houses have their own rules about who can touch what, minimum calls, and crew ratios. Those rules are not negotiable and they're not your production company's doing, but they absolutely shape the number.
- **Coverage.** Somebody has to be in every breakout, at every door, and on every camera, simultaneously. Concurrency drives headcount far more than attendance does.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

When a crew size looks high, the useful question isn't "can we cut two people?" It's "what breaks if we do?"

Schedule

Here's the lever most planners never think of as a labor decision, because it doesn't look like one.

Your schedule sets your crew size.

When load-in is compressed, because you couldn't get the room until 6pm, or the previous group is striking late, or the ballroom flips overnight, the work doesn't shrink. It just has to happen in fewer hours. The only way to do that is more bodies working simultaneously, and often those bodies are working past ten hours, at premium rates, with penalties attached.

Which leads to a trade almost nobody runs the numbers on: **an extra half-day of the room is frequently cheaper than the crew it replaces.**

Same with your show schedule. A general session that ends at 5:00 and a reception that starts at 6:00 in the same room is a labor decision disguised as an agenda. So is a rehearsal that gets scheduled after the last breakout instead of before the first one.

You control the agenda and, usually, the room block. That makes this the one lever where a decision you make weeks out can take real money off the labor line without touching quality at all.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

Send your production company the draft schedule early, and ask what it's costing you. The answer is often surprising and almost always actionable.

PUTTING IT TO WORK

What to do with this

Budgeting labor is a balance of cost against risk, and the stakes are real on both sides. Underspend and you're exposed in front of your audience. Overspend and you hit diminishing returns fast. Past a certain point, more money simply doesn't buy better results, it just buys more people standing around.

You don't have to make those calls yourself. But you should be able to interrogate them.

Five questions to ask before you ask for a discount

The next time a labor line comes back higher than you expected.

- 1 Which positions are you traveling, and what does each one cost me over hiring local?
- 2 What's the labor pool like in this market, and how did that change the crew plan?
- 3 Is this crew size driven by the complexity of the show, or by the schedule?
- 4 Where's the overtime exposure, and what would it cost to remove it?
- 5 If we cut one person, what breaks?

Any production company worth hiring will have real answers to all five. The answers will tell you where the money is actually going, and usually where some of it doesn't need to go.

We've spent decades on both sides of this conversation.

Your AV Department builds labor plans that hit excellent execution without padding, and we'll push back on an over-spec'd proposal, including our own, when we see a better way. If you'd like a second set of eyes on a labor line, send it over.

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